

Written Off, Not Done

A free sample: the introduction and the opening of Part 1

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Introduction: the Zoom call that explains everything

Six weeks into a search for a Data Center Operations Manager role, I got on a Zoom call with a recruiter who looked twenty-three, maybe twenty-four. Two minutes in, she asked me, straight-faced, "How are you with technology and AI? Are you comfortable using the technology?"

My resume was open on her screen the whole time. The one that listed the AI workflows I build, the automation agents I run daily, the Power BI dashboards and GIS tools and Smartsheet systems I manage for clients right now. She wasn't trying to be rude. She just couldn't square the gray in my hair with the resume in front of her, so she asked anyway.

It's a reflex, not malice. A recruiter early in her career, trained to scan for risk signals and moving fast through a stack of candidates, saw fifty-something and quietly downgraded "expert" to "needs to be checked." That happened in about two seconds, long before she read a single bullet point.

You've felt this. Maybe not in those exact words, but you've felt the pause after you mention your graduation year, the "wow, you've done a lot" tone that means something other than admiration, the rejection email that says "we went with a candidate whose background aligns more closely" for a role you were objectively qualified for.

This is measurable, and it's documented. You didn't imagine it. AARP surveyed 1,656 workers over 50 in the summer of 2025 and found that 64% had witnessed or personally experienced age discrimination at work. Ninety-one percent of the people who'd experienced it called it common. [1] A separate 2025 AARP survey found 74% of workers 50 and older believe age is a barrier to getting hired, and 42% call it a major one. [2]

But here's the part that matters more: knowing it's real doesn't get you a job. What gets you a job is understanding exactly where the bias lives in the process, and building a search that routes around it.

That's what this book does, part by part.

Part 1 names the problem precisely: what age discrimination actually looks like in a modern hiring process, where it hides, and what the law does and doesn't do about it. Part 2 fixes what's inside your control: your resume, your LinkedIn profile, and the story you tell about your own career. Part 3 is tactics: the ATS, your network, the interview questions nobody asks directly, salary conversations, and how to know when a pivot makes more sense than another year in the same lane. Part 4 is about staying credible and sane for as long as the search takes, plus what to do with the bridge income options that keep the lights on while you land the real thing.

One thing this book will not do is tell you to hide who you are. You're not going to fake enthusiasm you don't feel or pretend you don't know what you know. What you're going to do is stop making it easy for a hiring manager to reach for a lazy assumption, and start making it easy for them to see exactly what you're worth.

Why listen to me on this: I'm not writing this from a consulting office. I wrote this after a layoff put me back in the exact job market this book describes, at the age this book is about, running the exact search laid out in these chapters. Everything here got tested on my own search first.

Let's get into it.

Before you blame age

Age bias is real, you don't need this book to convince you of that. But it isn't the only explanation for a slow search, and treating it as the default answer for every rejection sends you fixing the wrong thing. Before you rewrite your resume for the fourth time, figure out where the process is actually breaking.

Diagnose first. Reposition second. Rewrite last. If the pattern says the lane is shrinking, change the lane, not the font.

Where are you in this, exactly

Over 50 isn't one experience. Three different fights are hiding under that label, and they call for different moves.

50 to 55: you're still competing for the same kind of role you've always had, dead center in the bias data this book quotes. The full playbook applies to you as written.

55 to 60: you're fighting the same bias plus a real question underneath it, reset or run out the clock. Read Chapter 14 and Toolkit K earlier than the page order suggests, bridge income and phased options aren't a last resort at this stage, they're a live option worth pricing out now.

60 and up: the real decision might not be full-time work at all. Fractional work, consulting, board work, or a phased wind-down can beat another ten-round interview gauntlet. Toolkit K walks through how to think about it, don't skip it assuming it's only for people further along than you.

Wherever you land, the fixes in Part 2 and the tactics in Part 3 still apply. This just tells you which finish line you're actually running toward.

Part 1: Name the problem

Chapter 1: It's not your resume, it's a filter you can't see

You've probably rewritten your resume three or four times this year. Different formats, different summaries, different keywords. And you're still not converting applications into interviews at the rate you should be, given what's actually on the page.

Before you touch the resume again, sit with this possibility: the document might not be the problem. The filter deciding whether anyone reads it carefully might be.

Here's how the euphemism machine works. Almost nobody in a hiring process says "we're worried you're too old." That would be illegal and they know it. Instead, they reach for language that sounds like a business judgment but is doing something else entirely.

"Overqualified" often means: we think you'll cost too much, get bored, or leave the moment something better comes along. Sometimes that's a real concern. Just as often, it's a polite word for "we assumed someone your age wants more money and less direction than we're offering."

"Not quite the culture fit" can mean a hundred honest things. It can also mean: this team skews young, and something about you, maybe your vocabulary, maybe your energy in the room, read as not-one-of-us.

"We went with a candidate whose background aligns more closely" is the rejection email's favorite non-answer. It tells you nothing about what actually happened, which is the point.

"Looking for someone more hands-on with current tools" frequently gets said to candidates who listed the current tools on their resume. The assumption arrived before the reading did.

None of this means every rejection is age discrimination. You've had rejections that were about fit, budget, timing, or a stronger candidate. That's normal and it happens to job seekers of every age. The problem is when age bias hides inside a rejection you can't distinguish from a legitimate one, because the language is built to be indistinguishable.

This is where the data gets useful. A national field experiment, published through the National Bureau of Economic Research, tracked what happened when researchers sent identical applications for real jobs, varying only the applicant's age. In the study's initial round of applications, candidates 40 and older received job offers at a rate 9.6 percentage points lower than younger applicants, against a normal 14.1% offer rate, that's a 67.9% drop, almost seven in ten fewer offers, just for being older. [3] That's a

lot of qualified people getting screened out before anyone even looks at their experience. (Chapter 10 breaks down who gets hit hardest.)

A separate NBER study found something sharper when it looked at electronic applications in two stages. At the resume-screening stage, when age wasn't visibly obvious, older and younger applicants were selected for interviews at almost identical rates. The meaningful gap appeared later: once the interview happened and age became visible in a name, a face, or a voice, the offer rate for older applicants was 12.8 percentage points lower, a 42.8% relative decline from the 30% baseline rate for younger interviewees. [3.1]

For many experienced applicants, the interview is where age-related assumptions become more visible than they are at the resume stage. That doesn't mean every late-stage rejection is bias. It means your interview strategy needs to make your relevance, adaptability, and motivation unmistakable, which is exactly what Chapter 10 is built to do.

That single finding should change how you think about your search. It means the fix isn't only about wordsmithing a document. It's about what happens in the fifteen minutes after someone sees you.

Exercise: audit your last ten rejections

Pull up your last ten "no" responses, or the ten most recent applications that went silent after 30 days. For each one, write down:

1. The exact language used, if any was given.
2. Whether you got an interview, and if so, how many rounds before the rejection.
3. Whether the rejection came before or after a live conversation.

You're looking for a pattern, not a verdict on any single rejection. If most of your "no's" come after you've been seen or heard, and almost none of your resumes get filtered out cold, that tells you something specific: your paper is working. Your search strategy from here needs to focus on what happens in the room, not another resume rewrite. Chapters 4 through 7 fix the paper anyway, because it still matters. Chapters 8 through 11 fix the room.

Composite example, not a real reader: a 57-year-old HR leader laid off in a corporate restructuring ran this exact audit on her last ten rejections. Eight of the ten had gone silent right after a first-round phone screen, before any in-person or video interview. That told her something specific: her resume was clearing the door. Something in that first conversation wasn't landing. She spent the next month rewriting her opening answer to "tell me about yourself" instead of rewriting her resume again, and her interview-to-second-round rate roughly doubled over her next dozen applications.

That's the sample. Here's where the rest of the book picks up.

Fifteen chapters. Twelve ready-to-use toolkits. Every statistic named, dated, and sourced.

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